

Conservatism



English country houses such as Chatsworth are often seen as bastions of the conservative ruling class ideal.

In striking a balance between liberty and authority, ‘classical liberalism’, as it came to be known, recommended that government should interfere as little as possible with the freedoms of its citizens. But among liberal thinkers, some held conservative views about who should rule, and how society should change. British parliamentarian Edmund Burke, for example, famously supported American independence and argued for relaxation of

political and economic pressure on the colonies, but as a conservative was opposed to the revolution in France. Burke believed that societies develop gradually into complex systems built on generations of accumulated wisdom – it is wrong to think that the theories of a single thinker or small group could suddenly replace the structure of a society that had evolved organically. He also thought that there should be a ruling class to safeguard the material and cultural assets of society, and that the aristocracy, born and brought up in a tradition of ruling with the experience of generations before them, were the best qualified for this role.